

Nikita Obraztsov

Sociologist of Religion | Computational Social Scientist | Science Communicator

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Education

MA, Computational Social Sciences (exp. 2027) European University at St. Petersburg

MA, Religious Studies (with distinction) St. Petersburg State University *Thesis: Belonging Without Believing: The Concept and Its Applicability to Orthodox Identity in Russia* Supervisor: Prof. M.M. Shakhnovich

BA, Law (with distinction) Moscow State University of Law (MSAL)

Research Interests

Sociology of religion, secularization theory, agent-based modeling, social network analysis, computational methods in religious studies, religion and digital culture

Publications

Books

Obraztsov, N.A. (2024). *Religii mira* [Religions of the World]. Moscow: Bombora/EKSMO. 208 p. ISBN 978-5-04-192309-9.

Orthodox Traditions and Holidays (forthcoming). Mann, Ivanov & Ferber (MIF). Under contract.

Articles and conference proceedings

Obraztsov, N.A. (2025). The concept of belonging without believing in the context of Orthodox identity formation in Russia. In: *Sociology and Society: Formation and Functioning of Social Memory. Proceedings of the VII All-Russian Sociological Congress*. Moscow, November 2025. EDN QUINAN.

Conference Presentations

2026

Network Segregation as a Temporal Buffer Against Secularization: An Agent-Based Model European Social Networks Conference (EUSN 2026), Norrköping, Sweden, August 2026. Endorsed by INSNA. Accepted for presentation.

Сетевая сегрегация как временной буфер против секуляризации: опыт построения агентной модели Computational Social Science Conference (CSS 2026), European University at St. Petersburg, May 2026.

Structural Limits of Religious Minority Resilience in Secular Society: An Agent-Based Modeling Approach All-Russian Academic Conference "Studies of Religion: Past, Present, Future", Russian Religious Studies Association, online, April 2026.

2025

"Belonging Without Believing" in the Context of Orthodox Identity Formation in Russia VII All-Russian Sociological Congress, Russian Society of Sociologists, Moscow, November 2025.

From Description to Explanation: Analytical Sociology as a Methodological Resource for Religious Studies XI Academic Conference "Religious Studies in Tsarskoye Selo" (in memory of M.Yu. Smirnov), St. Petersburg, November 2025.

Computational Methods in Religious Studies: Effectiveness and Limits VIII Congress of the Russian Religious Studies Society, Vladimir, October 2025.

The Popularity of Religious AI Chatbots as an Indicator of Religious Transformation II International Conference "Artificial Intelligence and Spiritual Culture", Plekhanov Russian University of Economics, Moscow, October 2025.

Honours and Awards

Triple prize-winner, IV All-Russian Student Olympiad "Sociologist in the 21st Century", European University at St. Petersburg, 2026:

- 3rd place, individual ranking
- Best Video Essay
- Best VCIOM Analytics Report
- Best Autoethnography

Winner, All-Russian Olympiad in Social Studies (VSOSH), national level, 2013.

Professional Memberships

Member, Russian Religious Studies Association

Teaching and Public Engagement

Pravoe Polusharie Introverta (popular science platform) Staff lecturer since 2022. 100+ lectures on world religions, Orthodox Christianity, and cultural history of religion.

Medio Modo (public lecture series) Public lectures in Moscow and St. Petersburg (2026):

- "Religion Without God: Buddhism, Daoism, and Secular Humanism"
- "From Discordia to the Flying Spaghetti Monster: Parody Religions in the Modern World"
- "What Does the Modern Person Believe? From Horoscopes to Neural Networks"

Levoe Polusharie Ekstraverta (YouTube channel) Guest lecturer. Video lectures on world religions and cultural history.

"**Ne Dai Bog**" podcast - host Popular science podcast on religion and culture. Pravoe Polusharie Introverta.

Media

Obraztsov, N. (2026). On parody religions and Pastafarianism [Radio broadcast]. *Fiziki i Liriki*. Radio Mayak. March 2026. smotrim.ru

Obraztsov, N. (2026). How neural networks are changing religious experience [Radio broadcast]. *Fiziki i Liriki*. Radio Mayak. March 2026.

Obraztsov, N. (2026). What does the modern person believe? [Radio broadcast]. *Fiziki i Liriki*. Radio Mayak. February 2026.

Maslova, L. (2024). Religion as social glue and spiritual analgesic [Interview with N. Obraztsov]. *Izvestia*. iz.ru

Obraztsov, N. (2021). On omens and superstitions [Radio broadcast]. *Byt Sovremennikom*. Radio Grad Petrov. December 2021. grad-petrov.ru

Computational Skills

- **R:** tidymodels, ggplot2, dagitty/ggdag, rvest, logistic regression, EFA
- **Python:** agent-based modeling (Mesa), data processing
- **Tools:** Gephi (network visualization), Zotero, Obsidian

Languages

Russian (native) | English (professional)